

KF45 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23-24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

I hope that you have taken a few minutes each day to practice **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. This breathing technique can help relax your body and refresh your mind. Not every technique works for everyone, so it is valuable to learn what works for you. We all have business to accomplish, and we all want to enjoy our business as much as we can. Mindfulness practices help us have a good time, more of the time, in the present time.

Let's begin with a body scan to connect our minds to our marvelous bodies. Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for twenty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. *(Pause for 20 seconds)*

Now turn your attention to your feet and ankles. What sensations do you notice there? *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Take a deep breath and move your attention to your calves and knees. Do you notice discomfort, pain, or perhaps twitching? Breathe and observe. Try to relax on the exhale. *(Pause of 20 seconds)*

Now begin to observe your thighs and hips. What do you notice? As you exhale, release with the breath any tension or discomfort that you find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Move your attention to your torso. Scan your abdomen, chest, and back. Observe, and then with the breath release any tension. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Now scan your neck and shoulders, arms and hands. Breathe, adjust, and release. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Observe your face. Breathe and relax any tightness or tension that you are holding there. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Now we will move to **Alternate Nostril Breathing**.

Begin to breathe using alternate nostrils. You can breathe naturally, or you might use the **Three-Part**

Breath. We will practice for four minutes, and I will give you a two-minute marker. *(Pause for 4 minutes, announcing when two minutes have passed)*

Pause. Breathe gently. Notice how you feel. *(Pause)* Now, open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting.

Our hymn of gratitude is *Great Is Thy Faithfulness*. This famous hymn was written by Thomas Obadiah Chisholm, who was born in a log cabin in Kentucky. He served in Christian ministry until poor health presented to him other opportunities.

Great is Thy faithfulness, O God, my Father;
Morning by morning new mercies I see.
All I have needed Thy hand has provided;
Great is Thy faithfulness, Lord, unto me.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We are exploring KF Confession 10:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

Doing the MATH is exactly like doing a financial budget, but when we budget our MATH, we honor not only the limitations of money but also the limitations of our abilities, time, and health. We honor these limitations so that we can determine our priorities and make choices before we find ourselves in situations that demand an immediate or difficult decision. Our choices are then based on real evidence and not on the illusions generated by our pride system and our fears.

Right now, you may be wondering how to budget your MATH for your KF work. You cannot use all of the KF tools all of the time. You have limitations. Allow yourself to simply learn about a tool; you don't have to thoroughly explore it right away. Choose the tool that works for you and practice using it until you feel ready to experiment with another tool. You are not in school. You don't have to know it all before the final exam. You are on a life-long journey, and you have all the time you need to grow.

Honoring your limitations helps you communicate more authentically. Your *yes* becomes a real *yes* based on real MATH, and your *no* becomes a real *no*.² People then get to know you for who you really are. They come to understand your real limitations. Some people can't handle their own limitations, so they will not be able to handle yours. Since they believe that they, themselves, should be above limitations, they demand that you should be too, especially if they crave your immediate and unlimited support. This is particularly true in families and, also, in organizations that depend on volunteers. If you have been willing to explore your limitations and have accepted that those limitations are your business, you will be more confident when you let others know where your boundaries lie. Breathe and connect with your priorities when others and your Idol are imposing their priorities on you.

In Western culture you will need help with budgeting your time. Your Idol Self loathes the idea of any time

limitation and will kick and scream whenever you do the MATH. Remember that you are not a machine that runs on a timer or a god that can manipulate time. You are a creature that uses timers to enhance your potential. Timers help you stay in charge. Use timers and alarms on your phone, your computer, or your watch, and buy individual timers at the store. When parenting my young and very verbal son, I learned to set a timer to limit his chatter. He was allowed to talk for fifteen minutes, and I allowed myself thirty minutes of quiet. A timer gave my son both the security of a boundary and an external authority that was not governed by his mother's whims or imagination. He and I agreed to be guided by this outside authority, and this chosen limitation reduced our anxiety. My son learned to relax because he could trust the timer to let us both know when he could talk again. While he talked, I was able to relax and be more respectfully engaged with him, knowing that my thirty minutes of quiet was not far away. By budgeting time in this way, I was honoring both my son's and my own design and taking into account our current limitations.

When you know where your time is going, you can be more flexible, and you can confidently resist anything that might steal time. If, however, you mindlessly fritter away time that could be spent in work, play, or rest, you are stealing from yourself and God. Overbooking is the same as going into time-debt. When your schedule is booked too tightly, you have no wiggle room to allow for the reality that events are not always under your control. Imposing an unrealistic timeline based on what you imagine should happen will also put you into time-debt. If you create unrealistic timelines based on pride and claims, you will find yourself opposed by God and the Creation. You might claim that you can accomplish a project in half the time that is normally required but then find yourself unable to carry out the project excellently or finish on time. Reality becomes your enemy rather than your friend because your pride cannot bear the evidence that you are not a magician who can wave a wand and instantly achieve fabulous results. When you submit to the limitation of time, however, you are choosing to be friends with reality.

You need to budget time for unplanned events, just as you need to save money for unplanned expenses. Unplanned events are a reality, so add fifteen minutes, several hours, or even several months here and there to give yourself margins. A positive balance in your ledger of time allows for flexibility when things go awry; for example, when you are confronted with slow traffic, a boss in crisis, or a sick child. It's crazy to believe that you should be magically exempt from surprising and unpredictable events. Such events are part of real living. If we schedule too tightly and adhere to the illusion that we can manipulate time, we actively add stress and confusion to our lives. We then end up with no time for real work and real play. Perhaps we overbook ourselves in order to get a self-hate fix. Poor us!

You need to get real about time. If you are actively adventuring, you will encounter perils, and if you want to pass through those perils peacefully, you will need to have resources in reserve. Every morning or evening, prepare your plans with prayer. Budget time for the unexpected. Ask God to do all that He can do, and ask Him to guide you to do all that you can do. Planning your day before you begin the day gets the energy flowing in the direction of *your* business and *your* priorities. Calendars, schedules, and alarms are all tools for planning and budgeting time. You can be sure that there are lots of people who, consciously or unconsciously, are planning their days with you in mind. There are energetic bulldozers and black holes out there who will push you around or suck you in, conscripting your resources to support their search for glory. All Idol types will do that. Your best offense is a good defense. Plan your day. Make a list of what must be done and what might be done if, by chance, you find that you have some extra time. Use the tools and techniques available to you as you pray, and ask God to help you use your time well.

You are a creature with limitations. You need time to work, and you need time to rest and play. Balance is what you are looking for, but life will not balance itself. You have to make choices that will help maintain

this balance. Some seasons and cycles can make greater demands on, or even drain, one or more areas of your MATH, and you will then have to consider how to redistribute your resources in order to bring some stability back into your life. Go joyfully into that training cycle because the current of the Creation will eventually reward you for your hard work. Our lives flow in tides, just like the sea. No sea creature fights the natural cycles of ebb and flow. Sea creatures take advantage of the flow when it comes so that they can replenish their resources and prepare for the ebb, which will also come. They circulate or restock according to the season and flow with the cycles as they come and go. Through their orientation to the Creation, they naturally know how to trust the authority of the tide. We are creatures, too, but our idolatry resists the natural circulation of the Creation. We can, however, get back in harmony with the Creation by choosing to honor the real limitations of time and of flow.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Wise Creator, teach me to use the gift of time well. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 10 reminds us that we can be grateful while exploring our limitations:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

In his letter to the Ephesians, Paul reminds us that Christians have always lived in misoriented cultures. Today, our culture is busy brainwashing us with the illusion that we can live a life without limitations. The market economy carefully fosters that illusion because it wants us to spend. Our society promotes the careless use of resources and then judges the real consequences of that carelessness as unfair. We are told that with little or even no training or effort we can do anything. We are led to believe that, without any adverse consequences, we can play more, work less, and dissipate our health through stress, food, inactivity, chemicals, and sex. When we have no money, we are encouraged to use credit cards. We are taught that we are all entitled to support and care, even if we choose to live irresponsibly. The Bible makes it clear, however, that no one gets away with anything. The outcomes of your choices will always be subject to the unchanging law of cause and effect, which is just as real now as it ever was. Ignoring your limitations will damage you and your community. As a Christian, you cannot afford to get caught up in cultural illusions. Misorientation is all around you, so you must make it your business to defend and train the unique and precious creature that you are.

Let's look at Nancy's translation and paraphrase of **Ephesians 5:13-18**.

¹³All reprobable things are revealed for what they are when they are exposed to the light. Or we could put it this way—everything that is revealed becomes a guiding light. ¹⁴For this reason it has been said, "Awake, sleeper. Arise from the insensible dead and Christ will illuminate you." His light will reveal the truth about you, and that truth will guide you to become more like Him. ¹⁵See that you walk around precisely, mindfully, and sharp-sightedly, not as foolish people without wisdom. Walk wisely. ¹⁶Walking wisely will buy

back the time wasted in time-debt. You must take control of your time because the times that we live in are very misoriented, and that environmental misorientation will seek to drive you into misorientation. ¹⁷Since this is true, do not be mindless and egocentric. Rather, cooperate with what the Lord desires—your orientation. ¹⁸Stop wasting your resources like a foolish drunk person. This kind of wasteful mindlessness fractures the soul. Instead, unify your soul by walking around mindfully and precisely, filled with the Spirit of God.

Take a deep breath.

You do not have the time to do everything. Karis Fellowships gives you lots of tools and encourages you to practice them, but you cannot use all of them, all of the time. You are like a craftsman who works with his tools as he goes about his business, using only the tools that are working for him today. He knows his tools, and he knows which tool is right for the job. You become efficient and save time when you know how to use the right tool for the job.

In this passage, Paul gives us guidance that helps us manage our resources, especially the resource of time.

1. We must allow every area of our lives to be revealed for what it is

How are you using your time? Are you using your time to save your Idol's life or to nurture your True Self? You need time to rest, work, and play.

Do you know that you cannot focus your mind productively for more than sixty to ninety minutes? You need to pace yourself, take breaks, and perhaps work on two completely different kinds of projects to give your mind a rest. Use a timer and plan ahead. How long will you work? How long will you play?

2. Wake up! Get real! Engage!

Allow the light of Jesus to shine on your life. Compare your life with His, and talk to Him about your training for today. Ask Him what qualities He would like to develop in your life.

Jesus is waiting to illuminate you. You might also think of it this way: He is the lighthouse keeper who lights the great lamp when it is night, but most of us will not allow Him into our lighthouse. We just stand there—dark, cold, lifeless, and unable to warn others of the rocks that will shipwreck their souls. You are a lighthouse in a storm-tossed and dark world, and Jesus wants to illuminate you with His light. When your lamp is lit, you will have the confidence to stand and shine.

3. Walk around, but do it carefully and mindfully

You must take control of how you use your time or else the market economy and your compelling needs will do it for you. They will steal your time in order to impose their priorities on you. You know the areas of your life that get hijacked by mindless living. Plan ahead. Snatch that time away from the jaws of the market and your Idol's mindless craving so that you can use your time for God's purposes and for your own. Ask God to help you see the areas of your life that get caught in reactive, mindless living, and then use A-S-K—Ask, Seek, Knock—to take back your life. Plan, and then simplify your plans. Those simple plans will include provision for the unexpected. Adventure into doing something different with your available time, perhaps learning a new routine or adding a tiny habit. Learn how

to protect your priorities. Prepare for the unpredictable, which will surely come. Buy back the time you have with A-S-A-P—Ask, Simplify, Adventure, Prioritize.

One of the best ways to take control of how you use your time is to create routines for your necessary activities. Routines cut out the constant decision-making, which wastes energy and distracts you from focusing on your priorities. When we go about our routines mindfully, our necessary activities become more efficient and more restful. Try taking a step toward efficiency by attaching a small activity to a routine that is already in place. For example, if meditation is difficult for you and you habitually drink coffee in the morning, try spending a minute in meditation before you have your first cup.

4. Cooperate with God

Rather than fighting against the currents of your life, learn to go with God's flow and stay connected to His guidance. The flags of discouragement, frustration, and chronic self-hate will let you know that you are fighting against the current or swimming against the tide. On many occasions, I have reluctantly chosen to let go of projects because of limited time. I have then witnessed God and the community competently manage the necessary projects on their own. Try not to focus so much on fulfilling your goals today, but, rather, as you work toward these goals, stay focused on your own training, your own development, and your own connection to God. Ask God and others for help, and do your best to create a balance of work and rest in your own life. It is through engaging with your limitations that you learn to trust God's ability to support you.

Misoriented people really do act crazy, like drunk people. Have you ever been controlled by or *drunk* with passions, fears, addictions, or compelling needs? When that happens, you cannot mindfully manage yourself. You get lost in your egocentric world, which is only concerned with your Idol Self and its pride. When you are drunk with misorientation, you are one of the insensible dead because you have shut out the living Spirit of truth and are under the control of another god. Paul warns us against drunkenness of all kinds, not just the drunkenness induced by alcohol. He calls God's people to be motivated by God's Spirit so that they can take their place as citizens of God's kingdom. When we walk wisely, refusing to be manipulated by this crazy world, we represent God and His kingdom and live as our True Self in correspondence with our Creator. We then have confidence that we are using our time well.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God and Creator, unite my heart to go peacefully with the flow. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and take your meditation posture. Breathe and relax. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider the limitation of time in an area of your life. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider the limitation of time in an area of your life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness

Allow your experience to remain in your awareness as you *consider the limitation of time in this area*. You might notice a compulsion to make up a virtue story or to push away or judge thoughts and feelings. Sometimes we flush away thoughts and feelings before they have a chance to speak to us and teach us. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you hold the limitation of time in your awareness. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider the limitation of time in this area of your life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what denial or stress feels like. Do time limitations make your body tense? *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can focus on an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this limitation of time*. Jesus might be asking if you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or numb. Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge limitations of time as good or evil? *(Pause)* Do you feel entitled to use time any way you like without adverse consequences? *(Pause)* Is this a regular pattern for you? Do you have a claim about time? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information. You might process with a long exhaling breath, or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore an area of limited time.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth, who loves the material creature that you are, living in time.
- Welcome your present reality, where you are today.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might consider these statements and make them a confession to the Lord as you turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.³

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I accept the limitations of time, I let go of the craving to get my own way.
- As I accept the limitations of time, I let go of the craving to gain approval.
- As I accept the limitations of time, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.
- As I accept the limitations of time, I let go of the craving for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for support and healing. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as we learn to manage our time. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to further our connection with our True Self and mission, with the Creation and our community, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *Great is Thy Faithfulness* by Thomas Chisholm (1866–1960), www.youtube.com/watch?v=dTKlqmdfHSk.

² Matt. 5:37.

³ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.